



**NED
DEBATING
SOCIETY**



NEDMUN VI

02 03 04

JANUARY



NED University of Engineering & Technology (Main Campus), Karachi

NEDMUN VI



UNITED NATIONS ENTITY FOR GENDER EQUALITY AND THE EMPOWERMENT OF WOMEN

- A) Strengthening Legal Protections Against Domestic Violence Globally
- B) Addressing the Gender Gap in Global Leadership and Political Participation

I. Introduction To The Committee:

UNWOMEN

The United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women (UN Women), created in 2010 by the General Assembly of the United Nations, is the UN body responsible for the promotion of women and girls' rights, empowerment, and well-being throughout the globe. UN Women is a very different organization from the Security Council or General Assembly in that it is a creative and active operational organization that not only supports the Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) but also develops global standards, policies and norms. UN Women also helps the countries in implementation of these commitments by providing technical and financial support. Its working is based on the principle that gender-based discrimination and violence are the major barriers to the development, peace and full realization of human rights. Leadership and political participation, economic empowerment, ending violence against women, humanitarian action, and the integration of gender perspectives into governance and national planning are some of the areas that UN Women work on. In a Model UN context, delegates in UN Women committees take on the roles of national representatives, experts, and advocates and work together to come up with very tangible, long-term and well-funded solutions to the most pressing gender equality issues in the world today.

The UNWOMEN's Mandate:

The UN Women's commitment to dealing with the issue of violence against women and girls, with special emphasis on domestic violence is supported by the international legal instruments such as CEDAW - Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women and its General Recommendation No. 35 that defines gender-based violence as discrimination-, the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, recurring UN General Assembly resolutions on the elimination of violence against women, and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development especially SDG 5.2. These legal and political instruments provide the basis and the way for UN Women to assist countries in the development and reform of laws and policies, implement prevention strategies that change the harmful social norms and act on the survivors' (health, justice, policing, and social support) needs by strengthening the essential services and conducting the data collection and analysis to inform the actions taken and decisions made which are effective and evidence-based.

UNWOMEN's Role in Strengthening Legal Protections Against Domestic Violence

The involvement of UN Women in this particular subject matter is very complex and varied and in different ways it has acted as the worldwide promoter, the technical specialist, and the coordinator. The functioning of the committee is very essential because, although almost all countries recognize domestic violence to be a breach of human rights, there are nonetheless global areas with major legal gaps and failures in implementation. These consist of lack of specific legislation in many countries, non-existing enforcement, bias in legal systems, and an acute shortage of funds for help services.

In this respect, the roles of UN Women are:

- **Normative Leadership and Advocacy:** UN Women's main agenda is to advocate for the end of violence against women and to keep it as a priority on the global agenda. Its advocacy for the ratification and implementation of relevant conventions, and holding governments to account for their promises, are all part of its strategy.
- **Technical Assistance and Capacity Building:** One of the most important functions is to provide governments with expert legal and technical assistance. This can involve the drafting of legislation that is comprehensive, victim-oriented, and up to international standards, as well as the training of judges, police officers, and prosecutors, and the establishment of specialized courts and services.
- **Catalyst for Data and Evidence-Based Policymaking:** The organization takes the lead in undertaking activities that aim at improving the collection, analysis, and use of data concerning the frequency and nature of domestic violence. Such evidence is vital for the creation of effective laws, the allocation of resources, and the assessment of the impact of interventions.
- **Founder and Implementer of Programmes:** UN Women is responsible for the management of a global fund and the implementation of programs in the field that test out contemporary methods of preventing and managing domestic violence, such as creating women's shelters and hotlines, and conducting public awareness campaigns that question existing attitudes.

II. Purpose Of Discussion

The aim of the conversation is to persuade the delegates to develop specific and implementable strategies that go beyond simply recognizing domestic violence. They should deal with the root problems that are preventing any further advances, such as the wide-reaching legal loopholes, the lack of law enforcement as the major factor in the situation, and the ingrained social and cultural patterns that regard violence as something normal. In addition, the proposed solutions must guarantee that the strong legal protections are accompanied by a survivor support services system that is fully funded and equipped to cater to the specific needs of marginalized populations. The objective is to bring about resolutions which, by providing an action-oriented, quantifiable, and comprehensive reform plan consisting of policy changes, resource allocation, capacity development, and partnership building across sectors, would ultimately ensure a violence-free life for all women and girls.

III. Introduction to agenda A; **Strengthening Legal Protections** **Against Domestic Violence** **Globally:**

Domestic violence (DV) is one of the most widespread and enduring violations of human rights, affecting millions of people every year. Even after decades of activism and awareness campaigns, the numbers remain alarming: almost 30% of women around the world have experienced physical or sexual violence at the hands of an intimate partner (WHO, 2021). And while laws protecting survivors have grown significantly—so much so that nearly 90% of the global population now lives in countries with some form of DV legislation—the reality is that these laws often fall short in practice (Our World in Data, 2023).

Domestic violence is more than just a criminal issue. It is deeply tied to gender inequality, social norms, economic dependence, and power imbalances that make it difficult for victims to seek help or escape abusive situations. Simply having a law on paper is not enough. Survivors need systems

that truly protect them: comprehensive legislation, trained police and judges, well-funded support services, shelters, accessible justice, and public awareness. Most importantly, the law must recognize all forms of abuse—including emotional manipulation, economic control, psychological harm, and coercive behavior.

This agenda challenges delegates to think beyond drafting laws. The real question is: How do we make legal protections actually work for survivors—no matter where they live, or what their circumstances may be?

Background:

Global Legal Progress: A Fast Rise, but Uneven Reality

Just a few decades ago, domestic violence was not legally recognized as a crime in most countries. It was often seen as a “private matter” or something to be handled within the family. This started to change with major international frameworks like CEDAW (1979) and DEVAW (1993), which pushed governments to acknowledge domestic violence as a violation of women’s rights.

The shift has been dramatic. In the 1990s, only a tiny fraction—less than 1%—of the world’s population lived where domestic violence was punishable by law. Today, that figure is close to 90% (Our World in Data, 2023). UN Women’s global database shows thousands of legislative measures passed across nearly every country. But progress on paper does not always mean progress in practice.

Many gaps remain:

- Only 104 countries have fully comprehensive laws covering all forms of domestic abuse (UN Women, 2023).
- More than 1 billion women still lack legal protection from domestic sexual violence (World Bank, 2018).
- Psychological violence, economic abuse, and coercive control are still overlooked in many legal systems.

What the Research Shows

Data from multiple countries shows that when DV laws are well-designed and well-implemented, they do make a difference. A study of 54 developing countries found that adopting DV laws led to an 11–20% reduction in multiple forms of violence (Sustainability Journal, 2022). A 2025 BMC

Public Health study confirmed this, showing that specific DV laws are more effective than general criminal codes.

Implementation: The Real Challenge

The problem is not the lack of laws anymore—it's making sure those laws work. UN guidance points to recurring problems:

- lack of trained police and judicial staff
- limited shelters and services
- weak monitoring
- societal stigma
- insufficient funding

For many survivors, even filing a complaint is incredibly difficult. Legal processes are slow, intimidating, and sometimes biased. And during crises—like the COVID-19 lockdowns—systemic weaknesses become painfully visible. UN Women described this as a “shadow pandemic” of increased domestic violence.

Examples From Around the World

Countries have made progress, but their experiences show the complexity of the issue:

- Brazil's Maria da Penha Law (2006) introduced specialized courts and services, yet enforcement is still inconsistent.

(Source :<https://www.unwomen.org/en/news/stories/2006/06/maria-da-penha-law>)
- India's DV Act (2005) covers many forms of abuse but relies heavily on civil protections, which are often under-resourced.
- Rwanda's GBV Law (2008) is a strong example of political will—Gender Desks in police stations and coordinated state action make it more effective.

These cases show that strong laws help, but effective enforcement, cultural change, and political commitment are what ultimately protect survivors.

IV. History/background of topic:

Domestic violence against women has been part of every society for centuries, emanating from deeply ingrained patriarchal structures that placed men in positions of authority and women as their dependents. Cultural and legal tradition allowed the husbands, in most ancient societies, such as those of Greece, Rome, and South Asia, absolute authority over the household. Physical punishment of wives was widely regarded as a just exertion of authority, while violence within the home was not considered a social concern but a private matter. Because of this, women had almost no protection under the law, and harmful practices were unquestioned.

These patterns continued during the medieval and early modern periods. The European legal systems, in particular, institutionalized doctrines such as coverture, which legally absorbed a woman's identity into that of her husband. Under such systems, women did not have the autonomy to report abuse, pursue justice, or even independent legal rights. Similarly, customary, traditional, and religious norms across many regions in Asia, Africa, and the Middle East also helped reinforce male dominance and normalize violence as an accepted form of discipline. Since domestic abuse was considered not to be a criminal act, state authorities rarely intervened, leaving women unprotected.

Even the rise of modern legal institutions in the 18th and 19th centuries did little to remove domestic violence from the margins. The police and courts usually treated incidents of abuse as personal family matters and would discourage women from pursuing them. No formal support systems existed for survivors, including shelters, legal aid mechanisms, or specialist services. Minimal political, economic, and social rights for women undermined further their ability to demand legal reforms or challenge discriminatory practices. Domestic violence thus largely remained invisible in public policy and unrecognized as a violation of basic human rights.

Indeed, it was only in the latter part of the 20th century that there was an emergence of international awareness, through women's rights movements, increased documentation of gender-based violence, and consistent civil society advocacy. Up until then, women all over the world had lived generation after generation without legal or institutional protection, trapped inside structures that legitimized domestic violence and offered no means of redress or protection.

V. CAUSES:

Despite its universal condemnation, domestic violence remains a serious global issue affecting millions of women. Since the legal systems designed to prevent it are often undermined by deeper societal and structural problems. In many cases, factors such as lack of education, economic dependency and gender based discrimination can contribute to the continuation of such abuse.

Patriarchal social norms:

At the core of domestic violence lies patriarchy, a system meant to privilege men in both private and public settings. Men are often seen as heads of the household, with women limited to caregiving and domestic duties. These norms restrict women's independence, justify control over their lives, and normalize the use of violence as a means of maintaining power.

Cultural and religious misinterpretation

In many societies, long-standing cultural beliefs and selective religious interpretations are used to excuse or minimize the impact of domestic violence. Traditions that emphasize family honor and male authority often silence victims, forcing them to accept abuse or even justify it rather than seeking help.

Gender inequality / discrimination:

Gender discrimination is one of the root cause of domestic violence. When a society systematically values men over women, it creates a power imbalance where the risk of coercion and abuse increases significantly.

Weak legal systems:

In many regions, laws are either poorly defined, not implemented effectively, or lack strict penalties, allowing perpetrators to act without facing any consequences.

Economic dependency:

Economic dependency on an abusive partner can trap individuals in violent relationships. Limited opportunities, lack of education, and low awareness often force victims to remain with their abusers due to financial insecurity and fear of poverty for themselves and their children.

Lack of awareness/education:

Limited education and awareness about abusive behavior and available support systems, especially in rural areas, contribute to the rise of domestic violence. Victims may not always recognize the signs of abuse or, if they do, may not know where to seek help.

Stigma and shame:

Another contributing factor is the stigma and shame faced by women who come forward to report abuse. Instead of receiving protection and support, they often encounter social blame and victim blaming, which discourages them from seeking help.

VI. EFFECTS:

SHORT TERM EFFECTS:

Violence against women can cause long-term physical and mental health problems. Violence and abuse affect not just the women involved but also their children, families, and communities. These effects include harm to an individual's health, possibly long-term harm to children, and harm to communities such as lost work and homelessness.

The short-term physical effects of violence can include minor injuries or serious conditions. They can include bruises, cuts, broken bones, or injuries to organs and other parts inside of your body. Some physical injuries are difficult or impossible to see without scans, x-rays, or other tests done by a doctor or nurse.

Short-term physical effects of sexual violence can include:

- Vaginal bleeding or pelvic pain
- Unwanted pregnancy
- Sexually transmitted infections (STIs), including HIV
- Trouble sleeping or nightmares

If you are pregnant, a physical injury can hurt you and the unborn child. This is also true in some cases of sexual assault.

If you are sexually assaulted by the person you live with, and you have children in the home, think about your children's safety also. Violence in the home often includes child abuse.¹ Many children who witness violence in the home are also victims of physical abuse.² Learn more about the effects of domestic violence on children.

If you are injured in a physical or sexual assault, call 911.

LONG TERM EFFECTS:

Violence against women, including sexual or physical violence, is linked to many long-term health problems. These can include:

- Arthritis
- Asthma
- Chronic pain
- Digestive problems such as stomach ulcers
- Heart problems
- Irritable bowel syndrome
- Nightmares and problems sleeping
- Migraine headaches
- Stress
- Problems with the immune system

Many women also have mental health problems after violence. To cope with the effects of the violence, some women start misusing alcohol or drugs or engage in risky behaviors, such as having unprotected sex. Sexual violence can also affect someone's perception of their own bodies, leading to unhealthy eating patterns or eating disorders. If you are experiencing these problems, know that you are not alone. There are resources that can help you cope with these challenges.

TRAUMATIC BRAIN INJURY RELATED TO DOMESTIC VIOLENCE:

A serious risk of physical abuse is concussion and traumatic brain injury (TBI) from being hit on the head or falling and hitting your head. TBI can cause:

- Headache or a feeling of pressure
- Loss of consciousness
- Confusion
- Dizziness
- Nausea and vomiting
- Slurred speech
- Memory loss
- Trouble concentrating
- Sleep loss

Some symptoms of TBI may take a few days to show up. Over a longer time, TBI can cause depression and anxiety. TBI can also cause problems with your thoughts, including the ability to make a plan and carry it out. This can make it more difficult for a woman in an abusive relationship to leave. Even if you think you are OK after hitting your head, talk to your doctor or nurse if you have any of these symptoms. Treatment for TBI can help.

MENTAL HEALTH EFFECTS:

If you have experienced a physical or sexual assault, you may feel many emotions — fear, confusion, anger, or even being numb and not feeling much of anything. You may feel guilt or shame over being assaulted. Some people try to minimize the abuse or hide it by covering bruises and making excuses for the abuser.

If you've been physically or sexually assaulted or abused, know that it is not your fault. Getting help for assault or abuse can help prevent long-term mental health effects and other health problems.

Long-term mental health effects of violence against women can include:

- Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). This can be a result of experiencing trauma or having a shocking or scary experience, such as sexual assault or physical abuse.⁶ You may be easily startled, feel tense or on edge, have difficulty sleeping, or have angry outbursts. You may also have trouble remembering things or have negative thoughts about yourself or others. If you think you have PTSD, talk to a mental health professional.
- Depression. Depression is a serious illness, but you can get help to feel better. If you are feeling depressed, talk to a mental health professional.
- Anxiety. This can be general anxiety about everything, or it can be a sudden attack of intense fear. Anxiety can get worse over time and interfere with your daily life. If you are experiencing anxiety, you can get help from a mental health professional.

Other effects can include shutting people out, not wanting to do things you once enjoyed, not being able to trust others, and having low-esteem.¹

Many women who have experienced violence cope with this trauma by using drugs, drinking alcohol, smoking, or overeating. Research shows that about 90% of women with substance use problems had experienced physical or sexual violence.⁷

Substance use may make you feel better in the moment, but it ends up making you feel worse in the long-term. Drugs, alcohol, tobacco, or overeating will not help you forget or overcome the experience. Get help if you're thinking about or have been using alcohol or drugs to cope.

SOME OTHER EFFECTS:

Violence against women has physical and mental health effects, but it can also affect the lives of women who are abused in other ways:

- Work. Experiencing a trauma like sexual violence may interfere with someone's ability to work. Half of women who experienced sexual assault had to quit or were forced to leave their jobs in the first year after the assault. Total lifetime income loss for these women is nearly \$250,000 each.⁸

- Home. Many women are forced to leave their homes to find safety because of violence. Research shows that half of all homeless women and children became homeless while trying to escape intimate partner violence.⁹
- School. Women in college who are sexually assaulted may be afraid to report the assault and continue their education. But Title IX laws require schools to provide extra support for sexual assault victims in college. Schools can help enforce no-contact orders with an abuser and provide mental health counseling and school tutoring.
- Children. Women with children may stay with an abusive partner because they fear losing custody or contact with their children.

Sometimes, violence against women ends in death. More than half of women who are murdered each year are killed by an intimate partner.¹⁰ One in 10 of these women experienced violence in the month before their death.

VII. CURRENT SITUATION:

Domestic violence continues to be one of the most widespread forms of gender-based violence globally, affecting millions of women every year. According to the [WHO Factsheet on Violence Against Women](#) nearly one in three women worldwide has experienced physical or sexual violence by an intimate partner. This makes domestic violence not only a human rights concern, but a major global public health issue.

Although most countries now have domestic violence legislation, major legal and practical gaps remain. UN Women's [Global Database on Violence Against Women](#) shows that **over 1 billion women still lack full legal protection**, especially regarding marital rape, coercive control, and psychological or economic abuse. Many nations still do not criminalize non-physical forms of violence, leaving survivors without meaningful legal recourse.

Implementation is one of the most serious challenges. As highlighted in UN Women's [Ending Violence Against Women Programme Overview](#) many countries lack trained police, effective judicial processes, accessible shelters, and survivor-centered services. Social stigma, economic dependence, fear of retaliation, and lack of trust in authorities further discourage survivors from reporting abuse.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, domestic violence cases surged worldwide. UN Women described this as the [Shadow Pandemic Report](#) noting that lockdowns heightened survivors' risks while

restricting access to help. In some regions, helpline calls increased by more than 60%, revealing long-standing weaknesses in protection systems.

Data collection also remains insufficient. The [World Bank VAWG Data & Research Page](#) shows that many countries either underreport domestic violence or fail to collect detailed, disaggregated data. This makes it difficult to design evidence-based policies or track progress.

Globally, responses remain inconsistent:

- In South Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa, patriarchal norms and limited economic independence trap many survivors in abusive environments.
- In Latin America, strong laws exist such as [Brazil's Maria da Penha Law](#) but enforcement remains uneven.
- In Europe, robust protections exist, but underreporting and slow judicial processes weaken them. – In conflict zones, instability dramatically increases risks for women and girls.

Overall, the current situation can be summarized into four major realities:

1. Domestic violence remains highly prevalent across all regions.
2. Legal protections exist but are incomplete or weakly enforced.
3. Cultural stigma and social norms silence survivors.
4. Support systems are underfunded, insufficient, or inaccessible.

Domestic violence is therefore not only a legal issue, but a **human rights, public health, and development challenge**. Effective protection requires stronger laws, reliable enforcement, survivor-centered services, and sustained global cooperation.

In summary, the **current situation** shows:

1. Widespread prevalence of domestic violence globally.
2. Stronger laws, but major gaps in enforcement and protection.
3. Deep cultural and social barriers that silence survivors.
4. Weak or inconsistent support systems.
5. A global push for coordinated action, but insufficient implementation.

This makes strengthening legal protections not just a legal issue, but a **social, economic, and human rights priority** for the international community.

VIII. UN PAST ACTIONS:

1. Adoption of CEDAW (1979)

- **Action:**
The United Nations adopted the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW), formally recognizing gender-based violence, including domestic violence, as discrimination requiring state action.
- **Significance:**
CEDAW became the foundational global treaty obligating states to protect women from violence and reform discriminatory laws. It established universal standards for legal protection and state accountability.
- **Source:**
[CEDAW – UN Women](#)

2. CEDAW General Recommendation No. 35 (2017)

- **Action:**
The CEDAW Committee issued General Recommendation No. 35, clarifying that domestic violence is a direct form of gender-based discrimination and expanding states' obligations to prevent, investigate, and punish such violence.
- **Significance:**
This recommendation strengthened the legal interpretation of CEDAW, requiring states to criminalize domestic violence, provide survivor services, and address structural gender inequalities.
- **Source:**
[CEDAW Committee – GR 35](#)

3. UN Declaration on the Elimination of Violence Against Women (DEVAW) (1993)

- **Action:**
The General Assembly adopted DEVAW, defining violence against women — including domestic violence — as a human rights violation and outlining state responsibilities. □ **Significance:**
DEVAW became the world's first explicit international framework identifying domestic violence as a rights-based issue, shaping modern national DV laws and international advocacy.
- **Source:**
[UN GA – DEVAW](#)

4. UN GA Resolution A/RES/58/147 – Eliminating Domestic Violence Against Women (2004)

□ Action:

The General Assembly adopted a dedicated resolution urging Member States to implement domestic violence laws, strengthen enforcement systems, and improve survivor protection mechanisms.

- **Significance:**

The resolution increased global political pressure on states, making domestic violence a recognized priority within UN human rights and development frameworks.

- **Source:**

[UN General Assembly – A/RES/58/147](#)

5. UN Women’s Ending Violence Against Women (EVAW) Programme

- **Action:**

UN Women launched and expanded its EVAW Programme, providing technical assistance to countries in drafting DV laws, training law enforcement, and supporting shelters and hotlines.

- **Significance:**

This program became a key operational arm of the UN’s global efforts, directly improving domestic violence response systems in dozens of countries.

- **Source:**

[UN Women – EVAW](#)

6. UN Trust Fund to End Violence Against Women (1996 – Present)

- **Action:**

The UN created a global funding mechanism supporting national and communitylevel projects addressing domestic and gender-based violence.

- **Significance:**

The Fund has supported over 600 projects in 140+ countries, enabling large-scale prevention campaigns, legal reforms, and survivor services.

- **Source:**

[UN Trust Fund – UN Women](#)

7. UNiTE to End Violence Against Women Campaign (2008 – Present)

- **Action:**

The Secretary-General launched the UNiTE Campaign to mobilize governments, NGOs, and communities to take coordinated action against domestic and genderbased violence.

- **Significance:**

The campaign globalized awareness efforts, including the annual “16 Days of Activism,” helping shift public attitudes, reduce stigma, and promote prevention.

- **Source:**

[UN Women – UNiTE Campaign](#)

8. Integration of Domestic Violence into the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 5.2)

- **Action:**

Domestic violence was formally included under SDG 5.2, committing all Member States to eliminate all forms of violence against women and girls by 2030.

- **Significance:**

For the first time, domestic violence became a measurable global development target, ensuring sustained international accountability and monitoring.

- **Source:**

[United Nations – SDG 5](#)

IX. Key Bloc and Country Positions:

1. Western / European Bloc (EU, UK, Canada, Australia, New Zealand):

Western nations generally take strong, proactive positions on domestic violence.

The **European Union** supports comprehensive legislation criminalizing all forms of domestic abuse, including psychological violence and coercive control. The **Istanbul Convention** is a major regional framework emphasizing prevention, protection, and prosecution. The **UK, France, Germany**, and **Nordic countries** advocate for robust survivor services, national hotlines, specialized courts, and government-funded shelters.

Canada and Australia also prioritize indigenous women's protection and improving data collection. This bloc typically pushes for **strict enforcement, survivor-centered systems, and strong monitoring mechanisms** in UN resolutions.

2. Latin America (Brazil, Mexico, Argentina, Colombia, Chile)

Latin American countries have some of the **world's strongest domestic violence laws**, influenced by feminist movements and regional frameworks like the Belém do Pará Convention.

Brazil's **Maria da Penha Law** is one of the most comprehensive, introducing specialized courts and police units. Mexico and Argentina advocate for expanded definitions of violence, including political and digital violence.

However, the region struggles with **high femicide rates**, limited enforcement capacity, and strong cultural stigma.

This bloc tends to support UN resolutions calling for **capacity-building, funding for prevention programs, and protection of vulnerable groups**.

3. **African Bloc (South Africa, Rwanda, Kenya, Nigeria, Ethiopia)**

African states have made substantial legal progress but face resource limitations and cultural barriers. **South Africa** has a strong legislative framework but high prevalence rates.

Rwanda is noted for successful implementation through Gender Desks and coordinated national systems. Many African nations advocate for **international funding, support for community-based solutions, stronger data collection, and culturally tailored awareness campaigns.**

They often emphasize the importance of **economic empowerment** as a tool for reducing domestic violence

4. **Middle East and North Africa (MENA) Bloc (UAE, Saudi Arabia, Morocco, Tunisia, Egypt, Jordan)**

Positions vary significantly across the region.

Tunisia has one of the most comprehensive domestic violence laws in the Arab world.

Morocco and Jordan have recently reformed laws to strengthen penalties and improve survivor services.

Gulf countries like the **UAE and Saudi Arabia** have introduced protective legislation but often face criticism over narrow definitions of violence and limited enforcement mechanisms. This bloc supports UN action but usually emphasizes respect for cultural norms, gradual reform, and capacity-building rather than aggressive international oversight.

5. **South Asia (India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka)**

South Asian countries generally acknowledge domestic violence as a major issue and have passed laws addressing it, but **implementation remains weak.**

India's Domestic Violence Act provides civil protections, but enforcement and awareness remain inconsistent.

Pakistan has passed provincial DV laws, yet cultural stigma and lack of resources hinder effectiveness.

This bloc often pushes for **education, awareness, economic empowerment, and international funding**, rather than strong external monitoring.
They highlight **family systems and social norms** as key challenges that need sensitive handling.

6. East Asia & Pacific Bloc (China, Japan, South Korea, Indonesia, Philippines)

Positions vary widely.

China's Anti-Domestic Violence Law focuses on mediation and protection orders but lacks strong criminal provisions.

Japan and South Korea support stronger protections but face underreporting issues.

Philippines and Indonesia have progressive legal frameworks but require better enforcement and rural outreach.

This bloc supports UN efforts related to **capacity-building, gender equality education, and improved law enforcement training**.

7. Russian Federation & Allies (Russia, Belarus, parts of Central Asia)

This bloc often takes a **conservative approach** to domestic violence legislation.

Russia partially decriminalized certain forms of domestic violence in 2017, emphasizing family unity over criminal punishment.

Central Asian states, however, vary: countries like **Kyrgyzstan** show stronger support for reforms, whereas others emphasize **cultural practices and limited external interference**. This bloc typically resists strong monitoring language in UN resolutions and favors **state sovereignty**.

8. Small Island Developing States (SIDS)

Caribbean and Pacific Island nations (Fiji, Samoa, Jamaica, Trinidad & Tobago) strongly support international action against domestic violence due to high prevalence rates and vulnerability during disasters.

They advocate for **funding, training, climate-related protection measures, and communitybased prevention programs**.

X. POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS:

1. Strengthening Comprehensive Domestic Violence Legislation

- Encourage states to adopt laws that criminalize all forms of abuse, including psychological, economic, and coercive control.
- Provide model legislation through UN Women to support states lacking legal clarity.
- Promote regular legal reviews to ensure national laws align with international standards.

2. Improving Law Enforcement and Judicial Capacity

- Train police, judges, and prosecutors on survivor-centered approaches and gendersensitivity.
- Establish specialized DV courts and fast-track procedures for emergency protection orders.
 - Create accountability mechanisms for mishandling DV complaints.

3. Expanding Survivor Support Services

- Increase shelters, 24/7 hotlines, legal aid clinics, and emergency medical services.
- Ensure funding for long-term rehabilitation including counseling and safe housing.
- Strengthen coordination between health, police, and social welfare institutions.

4. Strengthening Data Collection and Monitoring

- Support national statistical offices in collecting reliable DV data disaggregated by age, gender, and geography.
- Use digital reporting systems to track cases and identify high-risk regions.
- Publish annual national DV reports to increase transparency and accountability.

5. Public Awareness and Prevention Campaigns

- Launch nationwide media campaigns challenging harmful gender norms and stigma around reporting abuse.
- Integrate DV education into school curricula and community programs.
- Partner with religious and community leaders to correct harmful cultural interpretations.

6. Economic Empowerment for Survivors

- Develop job training programs and financial assistance for DV survivors.
- Promote equal employment and property rights to reduce economic dependency on abusers.
- Establish emergency funds to support survivors seeking to leave violent households.

7. Strengthening Community-Level Protection Systems

- Create community watch and early-warning groups trained to identify and respond to DV.
- Expand local women's committees to provide immediate support and referrals.
- Build partnerships with NGOs to enhance grassroots protection mechanisms.

8. Enhancing Digital Safety and Reporting Tools

- Develop secure apps and online platforms for confidential DV reporting.
- Train law enforcement to respond quickly to digital alerts and evidence.
- Improve cybersecurity protections for survivors facing digital harassment or stalking.

9. Ensuring Accountability and Justice for Offenders

- Establish guidelines for consistent sentencing in DV cases.
- Promote mandatory rehabilitation and counseling for offenders when appropriate.
- Encourage states to outlaw mediation in severe DV cases to prevent coercion.

10. Strengthening International and Regional Cooperation

- Facilitate cross-border training programs through UN Women, WHO, and UNODC.
- Share best practices on legal reforms, survivor services, and prevention strategies.
- Support regional conventions and platforms to harmonize DV protections.

XI. QARMA(Questions A Resolution Must Answer):

Q1: What minimum legal standards should all Member States adopt to effectively criminalize domestic violence?

Q2; How can UN Women support governments in enforcing domestic violence laws more consistently?

Q3: What mechanisms should be established to ensure survivors have access to shelters, legal aid, and essential services?

Q4: How can reporting systems be improved to make them safer and more accessible for survivors?

Q5: What role should national education and awareness campaigns play in preventing domestic violence?

Q6: How can Member States strengthen coordination between police, judiciary, healthcare, and social welfare systems?

Q7: What monitoring or data collection tools should be implemented to track domestic violence cases accurately?

Q8: How can economic empowerment programs reduce dependency and help survivors escape violent situations?

Q9: What accountability measures should be introduced to address negligence or mishandling of domestic violence cases by authorities?

Q10: How can international cooperation be strengthened to support countries with limited resources or capacity to address domestic violence?

XII. REFERENCES

1. **WHO – Violence Against Women Factsheet** <https://www.who.int/news-room/factsheets/detail/violence-against-women>
2. **UN Women Global Database on Violence Against Women** <https://evaw-global-database.unwomen.org/en>
3. **UN Women – Ending Violence Against Women (EVAW) Programme** <https://www.unwomen.org/en/what-we-do/ending-violence-against-women>
4. **UN Women – Shadow Pandemic Report (COVID-19 DV Impact)** <https://www.unwomen.org/en/news/in-focus/in-focus-gender-equality-in-the-time-of-covid-19>
5. **CEDAW – Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women** <https://www.un.org/womenwatch/daw/cedaw/>
6. **CEDAW General Recommendation No. 35** https://tbinternet.ohchr.org/Treaties/CEDAW/Shared%20Documents/1_Global/CEDAW_C_GC_35_8267_E.pdf
7. **UN Declaration on the Elimination of Violence Against Women (DEVAW)** <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/declaration-elimination-violenceagainst-women>
8. **UN GA Resolution A/RES/58/147 – Eliminating Domestic Violence Against Women** <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/512907>

9. **SDG 5.2 – Eliminate All Forms of Violence Against Women and Girls**
<https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal5>
10. **UN Trust Fund to End Violence Against Women** <https://untf.unwomen.org/en>
11. **UN Women – UNiTE to End Violence Against Women Campaign**
<https://www.unwomen.org/en/what-we-do/ending-violence-against-women/take-action>
12. **Our World in Data – Domestic Violence Legislation Stats**
<https://ourworldindata.org/violence-against-women>
13. **World Bank – Violence Against Women & Girls (VAWG) Research**
<https://www.worldbank.org/en/topic/socialsustainability/brief/violence-against-women-and-girls>
14. **Brazil – Maria da Penha Law (UN Women Article)**
<https://www.unwomen.org/en/news/stories/2006/06/maria-da-penha-law>

I.Intro to agenda B; UNWOMEN's Role in Addressing the Gender Gap in Global Leadership and Political Participation:

1. Introduction:

United Nations entity UNWOMEN established in 2010 to promote gender equality and women's empowerment worldwide. One of its core priorities is reducing the gender gap in leadership and political participation, where women remain significantly underrepresented despite progress.

2. The Global Gender Gap in Leadership

Women hold far fewer political leadership positions compared to men. Barriers include:

- 1 .Discriminatory laws and norms
- 2 .Limited access to education, funding, and networks
3. Gender stereotypes and unpaid care burdens
4. Violence and harassment in politics

UN Women addresses these structural and social barriers through policy, advocacy, and capacity-building.

3. Key Roles of UN Women

a) Policy Advocacy and Legal Reform

Supports governments in creating gender-responsive laws and constitutions.
Promotes temporary special measures such as gender quotas in parliaments.
Encourages alignment with international frameworks like:

CEDAW (Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women)
Beijing Platform for Action (1995)

Impact:

Helps institutionalize women's political rights.

b) Capacity Building and Leadership Training

Trains women candidates, activists, and elected officials in:

Campaign management

Public speaking and negotiation

Policy development and governance

Impact:

Strengthens women's confidence and effectiveness in leadership roles.

c) Increasing Women's Political Participation

Works with electoral bodies and political parties to:

Promote women's inclusion

Ensure fair electoral processes

Support voter education for women

Impact:

Improves women's representation at local, national, and global levels.

d) Combating Violence Against Women in Politics

Addresses harassment, threats, and intimidation faced by women leaders.

Supports legal protections and safe political environments.

Impact:

Encourages more women to enter and remain in politics.

e) Data Collection and Research

Produces gender-disaggregated data and global reports.

Monitors progress on women's leadership through indicators and indexes.

Impact:

Provides evidence-based policy recommendations.

4. UN Women and Global Initiatives

HeForShe Campaign: Engages men and boys as allies in leadership equality.

Generation Equality Forum: Mobilizes governments and civil society for gender parity.

UN Sustainable Development Goal 5: Achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls.

5. Challenges Faced by UN Women

Persistent patriarchal norms
Political resistance in some regions
Limited funding and enforcement mechanisms

Despite these challenges, UN Women continues to drive transformative change.

UN Women plays a critical and multidimensional role in closing the gender gap in global leadership and political participation. Through advocacy, training, legal reform, and global partnerships, it works to ensure that women have equal voice, representation, and power in decision-making processes worldwide.

UN Women plays a vital role in reducing the gender gap in leadership and political participation by supporting women's right to have an equal voice in decision-making at all levels. It works closely with governments to promote fair laws, gender-responsive policies, and reforms that remove barriers preventing women from entering politics and leadership positions. Through leadership training, capacity-building programs, and electoral support, UN Women helps women gain the skills, confidence, and resources needed to participate effectively in political life. The organization also addresses deep-rooted social norms and political violence that discourage women from leadership, while producing reliable data and research to guide evidence-based policymaking. By aligning its efforts with global commitments such as CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, and Sustainable Development Goal 5, UN Women continues to strengthen women participation in politics

Women's equal participation in leadership and politics isn't just an ideal — it's essential for inclusive, democratic governance and achieving global goals like Sustainable Development Goal 5 (gender equality).

Global Representation in Politics

As of January 1, 2025, women hold just 27.2 % of seats in national parliaments worldwide — meaning men still dominate legislative bodies everywhere.

UN Women Knowledge hub. This is up from only 11 % in 1995, showing long-term growth but also slow progress.

Inter-Parliamentary Union.

II. Purpose Of Discussion

The purpose of this discussion is to examine the role of UN Women in addressing the persistent gender gap in global leadership and political participation, highlighting why women remain underrepresented in decision-making positions despite international commitments to equality. It aims to understand how UN Women promotes inclusive policies, strengthens women's leadership capacities, and uses data and advocacy to support equal political representation. By analyzing facts, figures, and initiatives, the discussion emphasizes the importance of women's participation in leadership for democratic governance, social justice, and sustainable development, while also recognizing the challenges that continue to hinder progress toward gender parity worldwide.

III. Introduction to the topic: Addressing the Gender Gap in Global Leadership and Political Participation:

Gender equality in leadership and political participation is a fundamental human right and a key component of sustainable development, yet women remain significantly underrepresented in decision-making roles around the world. According to UN Women, women continue to face structural barriers — such as discriminatory laws, limited access to political networks, and social norms that restrict their participation in public life — which prevent them from fully engaging in leadership and politics. Despite their proven abilities as leaders and growing evidence that balanced gender representation improves governance, women are still far from achieving equal participation at all levels of decision-making. Equal participation of women is essential for realizing the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) by 2030 and building inclusive, democratic societies where all voices are heard.

IV. History/background of topic:

The issue of gender inequality in leadership and political participation has been recognized as a global concern for decades. Even though women make up around half of the world's population, they have historically been underrepresented in positions of power and decision-making at every level — from local councils to national parliaments and executive offices. Structural barriers such as discriminatory laws, cultural norms, limited access to resources, and political violence have restricted women's ability to participate fully in political life. As a result, men continue to dominate leadership roles across the world despite evidence showing that women's participation leads to more inclusive and effective government.

The United Nations and global partners formally highlighted this imbalance in 1995 with the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, which set a target of achieving gender equality in decision-making. However, even 30 years later, progress remains slow: women still occupy only a minority of parliamentary and executive positions globally, and projections suggest that achieving parity could take decades more at the present rate of change.

Recognizing these ongoing gaps and their implications for sustainable development and democratic inclusion, the UN established UN Women in 2010 to accelerate progress toward gender equality, including advancing women's leadership and political participation. Through research, policy support, and capacity-building, UN Women works to dismantle barriers and support women's equal participation in governance worldwide.

V. CAUSES:

Causes of the Gender Gap in Leadership & Political Participation

1. Structural and Legal Barriers

Women face discriminatory laws and institutional practices that limit their ability to run for office or participate fully in political life. These include unequal voting rights, lack of legal protections, and political systems that don't support women's access to leadership roles.

2. Gender Stereotypes & Social Norms

Deeply entrenched social and cultural norms often view politics and leadership as “men's roles,” leading to beliefs that women are less capable leaders. Such stereotypes reduce women's political aspirations and influence voter bias against women candidates. Nearly half of the global population believes men make better political leaders, according to the UNDP's Gender Social norms index

3. Limited Access to Education, Skills & Networks

Women often have less access to education, leadership training, political networks, and mentorship, which are crucial for campaigning and political success. These capacity gaps can weaken women's confidence and competitiveness in political arenas.

4. Financial Barriers Running for office

requires significant financial resources. Women frequently have fewer economic resources than men, less access to campaign funding, and limited financial support from parties or donors, making electoral competition harder.

5. Gender-Based Violence & Harassment

Women politicians face harassment, violence, threats, and intimidation both offline and online. Such hostile environments discourage women from entering politics or staying in leadership roles.

6. Resistance from Political Parties & Systems

Political parties often have male-dominated leadership and may resist promoting women candidates. Electoral systems (like winner-takes-all) also make it harder for women to win seats without strong party backing.

7. Work-Life Conflict

Women frequently bear a disproportionate share of unpaid care and household responsibilities, which limits the time and energy they can devote to political careers compared to men.

8. Post-Conflict & Security Challenges

In unstable or post-conflict settings, limited security and militarised political cultures further marginalise women, making it harder for them to engage in politics effectively.

9. Lack of Role Models

With fewer women in senior political leadership, there are fewer visible role models to inspire and mentor the next generation of women leaders.

10. Economic Inequality

Broader economic inequality — such as lower wages and job insecurity — weakens women's economic independence, making political participation less feasible.

Together, these causes — legal barriers, culture and stereotypes, lack of resources and networks, violence, party resistance, and economic inequality — interact to create a wide gender gap in leadership and political participation across countries around the world. Addressing them requires coordinated policy reforms, social change, and support systems — efforts central to the mission of UN Women and global gender equality frameworks.

VI. EFFECTS:

Effects of the Gender Gap in Leadership & Political Participation

1. Weaker Democratic Representation and Accountability

When women are underrepresented in political decision-making, democratic systems reflect only part of the population. This limits inclusive governance and reduces accountability to the needs of half the population, weakening democratic legitimacy.

2. Lower Focus on Social Issues

Research shows that women policymakers are more likely to prioritize issues such as healthcare, education, welfare, gender-based violence prevention, parental leave, and childcare — areas that broadly benefit society. When women are absent in leadership, these social issues may receive less attention and investment.

3. Increased Risk of Conflict and Less Peaceful Societies

Higher levels of women's political participation are linked with lower risk of civil war and reduced political violence. Countries with greater gender inclusion tend to have more stable and peaceful governance, whereas exclusion of women can relate to tension and conflict.

4. Economic Consequences and Slower Growth

Gender gaps in political leadership also impact economic outcomes. Studies show that when women hold more political power, economies grow faster due to policies that support gender equality in the labor market — including family-friendly policies, pay transparency, and better childcare infrastructure.

5. Reinforcement of Gender Stereotypes

Continued male dominance in politics reinforces harmful gender norms and stereotypes that women are less capable leaders. This discourages women and girls from aspiring to political roles and limits their ambitions.

6. Reduced Policy Diversity and Innovation

A lack of female leadership results in less diverse perspectives in policymaking. Women often bring different life experiences and priorities, which can lead to more innovative and comprehensive solutions when included. Without them, policy agendas can remain narrow.

7. Increased Hostile Environments for Women

Underrepresentation is both a cause and effect of violence, intimidation, and harassment against women in politics — including online abuse, threats, and psychological violence — which pushes many women out of public life and deters others from entering it.

8. Slower Achievement of Global Development Goals

Gender equality in political leadership is critical for meeting Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) — especially SDG 5 (gender equality) and SDG 16 (peaceful, inclusive institutions). Persistent gaps slow global progress toward these targets.

9. Less Responsive Governance

Because women leaders often promote social protection and equity-oriented policies, their absence means policies may be less responsive to the needs of vulnerable groups — including children, low-income families, and marginalized communities.

The gender gap in leadership and political participation has wide-ranging effects — undermining democratic inclusiveness, economic development, peace and security, policy responsiveness, and social progress. Addressing these effects is essential not just for women's rights, but for stronger, fairer, and more resilient societies worldwide.

VII. CURRENT SITUATION:

Global Overview

As of 2025, women remain significantly underrepresented in political leadership and decision-making roles worldwide. Despite decades of international commitments to gender equality, progress toward equal political participation has been slow and uneven across regions.

Women hold approximately **27 percent of seats in national parliaments globally**, reflecting only marginal improvement over recent years. Representation in executive leadership is even lower, with women occupying **around 23 percent of cabinet minister positions worldwide**. Only about **25 countries** have a woman serving as either Head of State or Head of Government, highlighting the persistent dominance of men in the highest political offices.

Regional Disparities

The level of women's political participation varies considerably by region. Europe and the Americas record the highest levels of female representation in legislatures, with averages exceeding 30 percent in several countries. In contrast, regions such as the Middle East and North Africa, Central and Southern Asia, and parts of the Pacific continue to show very low participation of women in political leadership.

A small number of countries, including Rwanda, Mexico, Nicaragua, Cuba, and a few others, have achieved or come close to gender parity in their national parliaments. However, these cases remain exceptions rather than the global norm.

Structural and Social Barriers

The persistent gender gap in political leadership is rooted in multiple structural and societal barriers. Gender stereotypes and cultural norms often portray leadership as a male domain, discouraging women from entering politics. Women in politics are also more likely to face harassment, intimidation, and political violence, which affects both participation and retention.

Additionally, women who do attain leadership positions are frequently assigned to social or family-related ministries, while men continue to dominate influential portfolios such as defense, finance, and foreign affairs. Young women are particularly underrepresented, indicating barriers at early stages of political careers.

Pace of Progress

While women's representation in political institutions has improved compared to the mid-1990s, recent progress has slowed. The proportion of women in national parliaments has increased from about 11 percent in 1995 to roughly 27 percent in 2025. However, current trends suggest that achieving full gender parity in political leadership will take several more decades if progress continues at the present pace.

Factors Supporting Progress

Certain measures have been shown to improve women's political participation. Countries that implement legislated gender quotas or electoral reforms tend to have higher numbers of women in parliament. Institutional mechanisms such as gender equality committees, leadership training programs, and legal protections also contribute to progress. Broader social changes, including improved access to education and shifts in public attitudes toward women leaders, play an important role as well.

VIII. UN PAST ACTIONS:

The United Nations has played a central role in promoting gender equality in political leadership and decision-making through legal frameworks, institutional mechanisms, global commitments, and targeted programs over several decades.

Foundational Legal Frameworks

The UN's commitment to gender equality in political participation was firmly established with the adoption of the **Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) in 1979**. CEDAW legally obliges State Parties to eliminate discrimination against women in political and public life, including the right to vote, stand for election, and participate in policy formulation and public office at all levels. It remains the most comprehensive international legal instrument addressing women's political rights.

Beijing Platform for Action (1995)

A major milestone was the **Fourth World Conference on Women held in Beijing in 1995**, which produced the **Beijing Platform for Action**. One of its critical areas of concern was women's unequal access to power and decision-making. The Platform called on governments to take concrete measures such as adopting gender quotas, reforming electoral systems, and promoting women's leadership in public institutions. It continues to guide UN gender equality efforts.

Security Council Resolutions

The UN Security Council has addressed women's political participation through the **Women, Peace and Security (WPS) Agenda**, beginning with **Resolution 1325 (2000)**. This resolution recognized the importance of women's participation in peace processes, post-conflict governance, and political decision-making. Subsequent resolutions strengthened commitments to women's leadership in conflict prevention, peacebuilding, and governance structures.

Establishment of UN Women

In 2010, the United Nations created **UN Women**, consolidating several UN entities to strengthen coordination and accountability on gender equality. UN Women supports women's political participation by providing technical assistance to governments, supporting female candidates, strengthening electoral institutions, and promoting gender-responsive governance at national and local levels.

Sustainable Development Goals (2015)

The adoption of the **2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development** in 2015 further institutionalized gender equality efforts. **Sustainable Development Goal 5** explicitly commits the international community to ensuring women's full and effective participation and equal opportunities for leadership at all levels of decision-making in political, economic, and public life. Progress toward this goal is regularly monitored through global indicators.

Capacity Building and Electoral Support

The UN, through agencies such as UNDP and UN Women, has implemented capacity-building programs aimed at increasing women's political participation. These include leadership training, voter education campaigns, support for women candidates, and assistance in drafting gender-sensitive electoral laws. The UN has also supported the adoption of temporary special measures, such as gender quotas, in several countries.

Monitoring and Reporting Mechanisms

The UN continuously monitors progress through reports by the **Secretary-General**, the **Commission on the Status of Women (CSW)**, and treaty bodies such as the **CEDAW Committee**. These mechanisms assess state compliance, identify gaps, and issue recommendations to accelerate women's participation in leadership and political processes.

IX. Key Bloc and Country Positions

Western and Northern Europe:

Countries in Western and Northern Europe generally adopt **strongly progressive positions** on gender equality in political leadership. Many support legally binding gender quotas, parity laws, and gender-balanced cabinets. These states emphasize institutional reforms, inclusive electoral systems, and accountability mechanisms. Nordic countries, in particular, often advocate for gender parity as a democratic norm and actively support UN Women initiatives and SDG 5 implementation.

Eastern Europe:

Eastern European states display **mixed positions**. Some countries support gender equality frameworks and align with EU-level commitments, while others emphasize national sovereignty and traditional social structures. Resistance to mandatory quotas is more common, with preference given to voluntary measures and gradual societal change rather than legally enforced parity.

United States and Canada:

The United States supports women's political participation through **capacity-building, civil society engagement, and electoral integrity**, but historically shows reluctance toward federally mandated gender quotas. Canada, in contrast, strongly supports feminist foreign policy, gender-balanced governance, and international initiatives promoting women's leadership. Both countries actively fund UN gender programs.

Latin America and the Caribbean:

This region is considered a **global leader in legal reforms**, particularly through the adoption of parity and quota laws. Countries such as Mexico, Argentina, and Costa Rica strongly support binding gender parity in legislatures and political parties. Latin American states often emphasize intersectionality, indigenous women's participation, and protection against political violence targeting women.

Africa:

African countries hold **diverse positions**. Some states, including Rwanda, Senegal, and South Africa, strongly support quotas and have achieved high female representation in parliaments. Others cite post-conflict recovery challenges, limited resources, or cultural factors as constraints. The African Union generally supports increased women's participation through continental frameworks and cooperation with the UN.

Middle East and North Africa (MENA):

Many MENA countries maintain **cautious or conservative positions** on women's political leadership. While several states have increased women's representation through appointments or reserved seats, broader electoral participation remains limited. Governments often emphasize gradual reform aligned with cultural and religious values rather than structural parity measures.

South Asia:

South Asian countries show **uneven progress**. Some support women's participation at local government levels through reservation systems, while national-level representation remains low. States in this bloc often highlight socio-economic barriers, education gaps, and political instability as obstacles to women's leadership.

East and Southeast Asia:

Positions in this region vary widely. Some countries promote women's leadership through party-based initiatives and institutional reforms, while others prioritize economic participation over political representation. There is generally **limited regional consensus** on adopting mandatory quotas at the national level.

China and Russia:

China emphasizes women's participation as part of state-led development but rejects external pressure or quota-based approaches, framing gender equality as an internal matter. Russia formally supports gender equality in principle but resists international monitoring mechanisms and binding commitments related to political participation.

Least Developed Countries (LDCs):

LDCs often support increased women's participation in principle but stress **capacity constraints**, lack of resources, and competing development priorities. These states frequently call for greater international assistance, technical support, and flexible implementation frameworks rather than binding obligations.

Civil Society and UN-Aligned States:

Countries closely aligned with UN Women, the Commission on the Status of Women, and SDG mechanisms generally support stronger international monitoring, gender-disaggregated data collection, and global cooperation. These states advocate for addressing political violence against women and strengthening accountability.

X. POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS:

1. Encourages Member States to adopt and strengthen national legislation that guarantees equal political rights for women, including the right to vote, run for office, and participate in decision-making at all levels;
2. Calls upon governments to implement temporary special measures, such as gender quotas or reserved seats, to increase women's representation in parliaments, cabinets, and local governments;
3. Urges Member States to invest in capacity-building programs, including leadership training, political education, and mentorship initiatives, aimed at empowering women to pursue leadership and political roles;

4. Recommends reducing socio-economic barriers to women's political participation by improving access to education, employment opportunities, financial resources, and campaign funding, as well as providing childcare and family-support services;
5. Emphasizes the importance of addressing harmful cultural norms and gender stereotypes through public awareness campaigns, educational reforms, and responsible media representation that promote women's leadership;
6. Calls for the establishment and enforcement of laws and mechanisms to prevent violence, harassment, and intimidation against women in politics, including online abuse, and to ensure safe and inclusive political environments;
7. Requests political parties to adopt internal gender-equality policies, ensure transparent candidate selection processes, and actively promote women into leadership positions within party structures;
8. Encourages international organizations, particularly United Nations bodies, to provide technical assistance, funding, and monitoring support to Member States for the implementation of gender-equality commitments;
9. Reaffirms the importance of international frameworks such as the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) and the Beijing Platform for Action in advancing women's political participation;
10. Calls upon Member States to collect and publish gender-disaggregated data on political participation to assess progress and guide evidence-based policy-making.

XI. QARMA(Questions A Resolution Must Answer):

K – Key Issues

- Women remain underrepresented in political leadership at national and international levels.
- Fewer women hold positions such as heads of state, ministers, parliamentarians, and senior policymakers.
- Gender inequality weakens democratic representation, policy inclusiveness, and sustainable development.
- Cultural norms and institutional barriers continue to limit women's access to leadership roles.

A – Actors Involved

- National Governments – responsible for electoral laws, political reforms, and representation policies.
- United Nations (UN) – promotes gender equality through UN Women, CEDAW, and SDG 5.
- Political Parties – act as gatekeepers for candidate selection and leadership opportunities.
- Civil Society & NGOs – advocate women’s political rights and leadership training.
- Women Leaders & Grassroots Movements – push for participation and policy change at local and global levels.

R – Root Causes

- Patriarchal social structures that prioritize male leadership.
- Limited access to education, funding, and political networks for women.
- Gender stereotypes questioning women’s leadership capabilities.
- Legal and institutional discrimination, including weak enforcement of equality laws.
- Political violence and harassment targeting women candidates.

M – Measures Taken

- Introduction of gender quotas in parliaments and political parties in several countries.
- Adoption of international frameworks such as CEDAW and UN Sustainable Development Goal 5.
- Leadership training programs and mentorship initiatives for women.
- Awareness campaigns promoting women’s role in governance.
- Electoral reforms to ensure equal political participation.

A – Assessment (Effectiveness & Gaps)

- Gender quotas have increased women’s representation but implementation remains uneven.
- Progress is slow and inconsistent across regions, especially in developing countries.
- Lack of political will and weak enforcement reduce policy impact.
- Cultural resistance and security threats still discourage women from active participation.
- Long-term change requires structural reforms, education, and societal mindset shifts.

XII. REFERENCES

<https://knowledge.unwomen.org/en/digital-library/publications/2025/03/women-in-politics-map-2025>

<https://www.ipu.org/news/press-releases/2025-03/political-leadership-roles-in-2025-men-continue-dominate> [Inter-Parliamentary Union](#)

<https://www.ipu.org/news/press-releases/2025-03/ipu-report-parliamentary-gender-gap-narrowed-over-past-30-years-progress-stalled-in-2024>

<https://knowledge.unwomen.org/en/articles/facts-and-figures/facts-and-figures-womens-leadership-and-political-participation>

https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/report/2025/extended-report/Extended-Report-2025_Goal-5.pdf [UNSD](#)